AN EMBATTLED IMRAN

Ever since he lost power in April 2022, Imran Khan has striven to take the fight to the ruling PML(N)-led coalition. But his aggressive rhetoric has also landed him in legal trouble. A guide to the most significant charges against him

THE TOSHAKHANA CASE

Imran Khan is charged with taking gifts from the Toshakhana—which stores gifts received by public officials— at high discounts and selling them off for hefty profits that he did never declared in tax returns. Cornered by a case filed against him by the PML(N) regime in Aug. '22, Khan admitted to selling some items, including a Graff watch gifted to him by Saudi crown prince Mohammed bin Salman, in a letter to the Election Commission of Pakistan (ECP). The total worth of the gifts, including Rolex watches and jewellery, was Rs 154 million (PKR). The ECP, accusing him of making false declarations, barred him from office for five years under Article 63(1)(p) of the Constitution. Khan petitioned against this in the Islamabad High Court (IHC), where it was rejected. A sessions court in Islamabad put out a non-bailable arrest warrant after Khan repeatedly ignored its summons.

ANTI-TERROR CHARGES

These charges emerge directly from the ECP disqualification. Soon after news broke of it, the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) workers protested in front of ECP offices, clashing with police. An anti-terrorism court in Islamabad filed a case against Khan, alleging he and other leaders incited the protests. Khan was given interim bail, but failed to appear in court repeatedly, citing health and security reasons. On Feb. 15, the court refused to extend his bail. But on Feb. 20, the Lahore HC granted Khan bail in this case.



FEMALE JUDGE 'THREAT' CASE

At a rally in Islamabad on Aug. 20, 2022, organised in solidarity with his arrested aide Shahbaz Gill, Khan allegedly threatened ECP officials and rivals with legal action. Special venom was reserved for Judge Zeba Chaudhry, who had approved Gill's two-day remand. Besides an FIR, the IHC began contempt of court proceedings against him. In Sept., Khan, in an affidavit, admitted to having "crossed a line" and said he would apologise to Judge Chaudhry. The IHC removed the terror and contempt charges, but the 'threat' case went on in a sessions court. Khan, again, did not respond to its summons. On Mar. 13, 2023, an NBW was issued and the police were asked to present him before the court by Mar. 29. On appeal, the warrant was suspended till Mar. 16.

PROHIBITED FUNDING CASE

This case, originally filed in 2014, alleges funding irregularities by the PTI. On Aug. 2, '22, the ECP, after a probe, charged the PTI with receiving funding from prohibited sources—including 34 foreign nationals and 351 foreign-based companies. To divert these funds, it said, the PTI took ownership of eight bank accounts and concealed 13. Khan's submissions about party funds in 'Form 1' were found to be "grossly inaccurate" for five years in a row. The ECP served a showcause to the party, asking why the funds shouldn't be confiscated. The Federal Investigation Agency (FIA) registered a case against Khan and other PTI leaders considered beneficiaries of the monies. On Feb. 2, the IHC rejected the PTI's petition against the ECP's ruling. A banking court in Islamabad had also rejected Khan's request for a virtual hearing and asked him to appear in person on Feb. 15. The IHC barred that court from ruling on Khan's bail plea in the case. On Feb. 28, when Khan appeared in court, it postponed proceedings, citing security concerns.

'ATTEMPT TO MURDER'

This charge was filed by PML(N) leader Mohsin Nawaz Ranjha in Oct. '22 after he was allegedly attacked by PTI demonstrators outside the ECP office in Islamabad. On Feb. 28, the IHC granted Khan interim bail.

↘ **'KP Helicopter Case'**: Filed with the National Accountability Bureau for alleged misuse of the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa government resources.

↘ **'Cipher Audio Leak'**: In Dec. 2022, FIA probed charges that Khan and two senior PTI leaders discussed if Pakistan's secret diplomatic code could be used to build a narrative about a 'foreign conspiracy' against him.

↘ **'PTI chairmanship'**: The ECP served a notice seeking to remove Khan from PTI chairmanship, saying the Toshakhana disqualification would entail this. On Jan. 4, Khan challenged it in the Lahore HC. The next day, the HC stayed the ECP action. However, the ECP has directed Khan to submit his reply in the case.